By May 2019, roughly one in every three Indians was using apps or digital tools like Facebook (up from 9 per cent in 2014), WhatsApp or YouTube.[21] This cheap data revolution, triggered by the launch of the Jio phone network in September 2016, also transformed Indian politics. Digital penetration figures show that widespread adoption of technology may have been the single biggest politics-shifting event of the past decade, altering the neural structures of how local political mobilisation works.

The 2019 general election was, in that sense, India's 'first post-Jio-election', as the journalist Saba Naqvi has perceptively argued. As she put it, 'Some commentators have asked whether this was a post-caste and post-identity mandate, and thereby, a post-Mandal one … I believe that the change has been driven by technology in general, and the telecom revolution ushered in by Jio in particular.'[22] This data revolution created possibilities for political parties to reach voters one-to-one on a larger scale than had ever been possible before. It made traditional media channels obsolete and far less influential, allowing political parties to create their own media channels.

Crucially, this expansion broke down the digital divide. Chatting over coffee at Googleplex, Google's headquarters in California, on a hot, sunny day in May 2019, Caesar Sengupta, the man who then headed the company's initiative to get the Next Billion Users worldwide and Digital Payments, told me that, by 2019, 95 per cent of digital video consumption was already in regional languages, not English. By then, he said, Google had begun to receive more voice searches, as opposed to text searches, from India than any other country in the world. This was driven by the growth of regional languages online. He estimated that Hindi internet users would overtake English users by 2021. Marathi was the next biggest, but Tamil, Telugu and Kannada exhibited the 'highest internet adoption rates'. Also, by 2019, about two-thirds of Google Pay payments were coming from small towns and rural India, outside the eight big metros.[23]

Ajit Mohan, Facebook's vice president and managing director for India, emphasised in a video chat with me in July 2020 that there was 'clearly a shift from offline to online'. This was why Facebook